

FROM FRAGMENTATION TO FUNCTION
SOUTH AFRICA'S MULTILATERAL MOMENT

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The world order is shifting in profound and unpredictable ways. Global governance, once anchored in cooperative multipolarity, now reflects deep fragmentation, competing norms, and declining trust among major powers. As Nathalie Tocci of the Istituto Affari Internazionali argues, the world today is "multipolar, but not cooperative – fragmented and normatively incoherent." This incoherence has narrowed the space for cooperation, even as global polycrises demand collective solutions.

For middle powers like South Africa, this landscape offers both constraint and opportunity. Influence can no longer rest on moral authority or symbolic representation alone; it must be exercised through strategic, layered engagement.

Through its membership in both BRICS and the G20, South Africa can pursue a multipronged approach focused on three interlocking spheres – economy, security, and diplomacy. Together, this approach will enable the successful navigation of a fragmentated and evolving multilateral world order.

Economy: From fragility to flexibility

Geoeconomic relations have evolved from being defined by shifts brought on by war or recession to the gradual erosion of principles that have underpinned the multilateral system. In the trade arena, unpredictable Western engagement has accelerated the weakening of global value chains, rules and institutions, which many African countries have only recently been integrated into.

A case in point is the impact of the Trump administration's tariffs on countries such as Madagascar, Lesotho and Kenya – countries previously rewarded for their adherence to trade norms and use of the African Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA) – who are now subject to fragility, market restrictions and constrained fiscal space amidst existing increasing inequality and declining economic growth rates that characterise the continent.

Conversely, major actors are now pursuing unilateral and selective engagement strategies. With a preference for bilateral trade agreements and exclusive trading blocs, the global trading system is no longer defined by shared norms but by changing power dynamics.

For South Africa and middle powers alike, these dynamics represent an inflection point whereby countries can no longer rely on existing mechanisms that have encouraged integration into the global economy. Rather, they must use multilateralism to counter fragility with flexibility by rethinking and reshaping their economic futures.

Multilateral groupings provide ample opportunity to create diversified trade partnerships. This is most strongly evident in African countries' trade partnerships with all BRICS countries, which contributed to South-South trade surging from USD 600 billion in 1995 to over USD 5.3 trillion by 2021, surpassing North-South trade. But, the University of Cape Town's Carlos Lopes rightly asserts that "diversification alone is not enough... countries must invest in building regional resilience" through initiatives such as the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), which will enable a wholesale reimagining of Africa's position and contribution to global trade flows.

Similarly, groupings like the G20 and BRICS provide a platform for South Africa to address the fundamental gap between conditions which threaten Africa's economic security and the tools available to remedy them. The most tenable of which are the continent's growing debt and reliance on development financing.

While both BRICS and the G20 have introduced frameworks and even institutions to shift conversations around development financing and debt repayments, South Africa must maintain the push for modest reforms such as greater transparency, more predictable timelines and the inclusion of non-traditional creditors. More so, it must increase the pushback against biased credit ratings and explore innovative financial mechanisms such as blended finance, regional development funds and climate-linked investment.

These efforts will go far in ensuring that multilateralism remains both a valuable tool for developing countries to exert substantive economic influence in the global economic landscape, notwithstanding unpredictable economic power shifts and systemic constraints.